

Floriade: Spring in Australia [B1]

Quando in Europa arriva l'autunno, in Australia è primavera. A Canberra, la capitale, si celebra la nuova stagione con un festival floreale di 30 giorni.



Spring starts in September in the southern hemisphere. As the leaves start falling in the north, flowers start [to blossom](#) below the equator. The capital of Australia

literally comes into bloom as it welcomes the new season with a colourful flower festival. [Hailed](#) as “Australia’s biggest celebration of spring”, Floriade returns to Canberra’s Commonwealth Park, from 14 September to 13 October.

A MILLION PLANTS

Floriade is more than a pretty flower show. A million bulbs and annuals are planted across four hectares of the park, alongside Lake Burley Griffin. Huge displays of flowering bulbs are punctuated by a variety of artistic features. Every year has a different theme, usually centred around historic or cultural events. Previous themes have included music (1991), Aussieicons, myths and legends (2007) and World War One remembrance (2015). This year’s theme is Art in Bloom. The organisers promise something special: “For thirty enchanting days, visitors will witness a harmonious [blend](#) of horticulture and art, with garden bed designs inspired by painting, sculpture, architecture, literature, music, theatre and cinema.”

DUTCH INSPIRATION

Floriade was conceived by landscape architect Christiaan Slotemaker de Bruine and horticulturist Peter Sutton, who worked for City Parks. The name Floriade is derived from the Latin ‘floreare’, which means ‘to design with flowers’. The initial design was inspired by the famous Keukenhof Gardens in the Netherlands, which also holds a Floriade event every ten years. The concept was the nation’s multiculturalism. Featuring Dutch and Aboriginal floral [patterns](#), it was sponsored by the Dutch Embassy and the Bicentennial Authority.

DOUBLE CELEBRATION

The first Floriade was held in 1988, to celebrate the capital’s 75th birthday and Australia’s Bicentenary of European settlement. Accompanied by a programme of live music and entertainment, it was an enormous success. Initially intended as a [one-off](#) event, its popularity convinced authorities to make it an annual celebration.

FLORIADE TODAY

Floriade has since grown into the largest flower festival in the southern hemisphere, [drawing](#) up to half a million visitors. Despite being free to enter, it brings in around A\$35-45 million [€21-27 million] every year. Besides the floral displays, it includes NightFest, four nights of after-dark entertainment and horticultural illuminations, and a gnome-decorating competition, run by the Rotary Club to raise funds for charity. In addition to the park, a tulip [trail](#) runs

through the suburbs, thanks to 300,000 bulbs and annuals planted by local schools and community groups.

Glossary

- **Hailed** = considerare
- **blend** = miscela, mescolanza
- **patterns** = motivi
- **one-off** = unico
- **drawing** = attirare
- **trail** = sendero, camino
- **to blossom** = fiorire